

STAGE FIFTEEN • BUSINESS & ORGANIZATIONAL ACUMEN

FIRSTS

GROUP VERSIONS OF KEY EXERCISES

Live, group-adapted versions of the FIRSTS that benefit most from interaction

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Group Versions of Key Exercises

Stage Fifteen • Business & Organizational Acumen

PURPOSE

Stage Fifteen's worksheets are written for solo analysis — map your own stakeholders, build your own business case, research your own competitors. But business acumen is fundamentally a discipline of catching your own blind spots, and outside perspective is often the fastest way to catch them. A partner assigned to genuinely challenge a proposed root cause, or an outside pair testing whether a recommendation is actually clear, routinely surfaces gaps solo work misses.

This document adapts six FIRSTS across all three sections of Stage Fifteen. As with every stage, these are additions, not replacements — participants complete their own individual analysis first, and the group version stress-tests it.

Several of these are explicitly structured as adversarial or challenging (the Devil's Advocate Round, the Role-Swap Panel) rather than purely supportive — that's intentional. Business analysis improves under genuine scrutiny in a way it doesn't under purely encouraging feedback.

The Six Adapted Exercises

FIRST S3

Department Function Mapping — Cross-Team Interview Swap

TIME: +15 min beyond framing

1. If participants come from different organizations or departments, pair people up across those lines.
2. Partner A explains what they believe Partner B's department/team genuinely does, based on outside impression only.
3. Partner B corrects and clarifies, then the pair swaps roles.
4. Debrief as a full group: what's one assumption about another function that turned out to be genuinely wrong?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Outside assumptions about another department are often specifically wrong in instructive ways — hearing the correction directly from someone who actually does the work lands harder than reading a generic description.

FIRST S10

Stakeholder Mapping Exercise — Blind Spot Swap

TIME: +15 min beyond solo mapping

1. After individual stakeholder mapping, pairs exchange their lists.
2. Each partner spends 2 minutes trying to add one stakeholder the other person's list is missing.
3. Compare additions: which missed stakeholders were internal versus external?

FACILITATOR NOTE

This directly tests the Common Pitfall named in this FIRST — only mapping internal stakeholders. A partner's outside eyes reliably catch external stakeholders (regulators, partners, customers) that the original mapper missed.

FIRST S13

Business Problem Analysis — Devil's Advocate Round

TIME: +15 min beyond solo analysis

1. After identifying a candidate root cause individually, pairs take turns.
2. Partner A states their proposed root cause. Partner B's only job is to push back: “what if it's actually something else — could it be X instead?”
3. Partner A responds directly to each challenge, either defending the root cause with real evidence or revising it.
4. Swap roles.

FACILITATOR NOTE

This directly stress-tests the Common Pitfall of jumping to the first plausible explanation. A partner whose job is explicitly to challenge, not just agree, makes the analysis genuinely more rigorous.

FIRST S16

Business Recommendation — Recommendation Pitch

TIME: +15 min beyond solo drafting

1. Each participant delivers their recommendation aloud to a partner in under 60 seconds, as if the partner were the actual decision-maker.
2. Partner gives one piece of feedback: was the recommendation genuinely clear and actionable, or did it stay hedged and vague?
3. Revise and re-deliver once based on that feedback.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Saying a recommendation out loud, under a time constraint, reveals hedging that's easy to miss on paper — a recommendation that takes 90 seconds of qualification before reaching a point usually isn't actually a clear recommendation yet.

FIRST S18

Competitive Analysis — Panel Comparison

TIME: +15 min beyond solo research

1. Small groups where participants have researched different organizations compare their competitive matrices side by side.
2. Each person presents their strongest, most surprising finding in one sentence.
3. Group discusses: are there common competitive dynamics showing up across genuinely different industries?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Seeing multiple real competitive analyses side by side, even from unrelated industries, often reveals that certain competitive dynamics (price versus differentiation, incumbent versus disruptor) repeat across contexts — a useful, generalizable insight beyond any single participant's own research.

FIRST S21

Executive Perspective Exercise — Role-Swap Panel

TIME: +20 min beyond solo reflection

1. Small groups of 3–4. Each person briefly presents a real problem from their own role's perspective.
2. The rest of the group, acting as a mock executive panel, asks questions specifically aimed at broader organizational implications: risk, resource trade-offs, cross-team impact.
3. The presenter responds in real time, then the group moves to the next person.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Being asked genuine executive-style questions live, rather than just imagining them alone, makes the perspective shift far more concrete — and often surfaces considerations the presenter hadn't thought of, which is the entire point of this FIRST.